THE KONKERS

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CHAPTER 1

FISHING

Tom Watt and Billy Roberts sat on the riverbank and waited for the first fish to bite.

Billy was bored, but Tommy was determined to catch something.

"Oh come on Tommy, that's it. I've had it. It's been long enough now! grumbled Billy.

"Just a bit longer. It could be any minute now!"

"You said that before!" complained Billy. "I'm fed up. My bottom's sore from sitting on this hard ground and I'm freezing cold!"

"I must catch something! said Tommy.

"Well, I'm going soon if you don't. So much for your lucky feeling. All I feel is numb now!"

Tommy still clung rigidly onto his make-shift rod. He looked thoroughly fed up. "I'm sure I was right. When I feel lucky, something good always happens!

Just then, the line tugged and Tommy could see something moving just under the surface. He flicked his rod and pulled quickly on the line till whatever it was, was securely caught on the hook.

"Look! What did I tell you? I've caught something! he shouted.

What he pulled up, however, was not exactly what he had

expected. Wriggling and squirming on the end of his line was a little man, no bigger that a mouse, with a head which looked like a horse chestnut. It might even have been a horse chestnut with arms and legs.

The little person was furious. He was shaking his fists in the air and on his back was what looked like two tiny air tanks; the kind that divers use.

"How dare you!" he shouted in a surprisingly clear voice.

The end of Tommy's line was completely tangled in the tiny swimmer's air pipe and the hook was fastened onto his tanks. "You could have killed me," he said indignantly.

Tommy and Billy were flabbergasted. "What is it?" gasped Tommy.

"I am a Konker! said the little man. "Now, will you kindly let me down?"

. . .

BILLY IGNORED HIM. "We must show the others this. They'll never believe it, he said to Tom, taking no notice at all of the Konker's words. He grabbed the wriggling creature from Tommy's hook and quickly stuffed it deep into the haversack and closed it tight shut. The Konker had not the slightest chance of escape because it had all happened so quickly.

The two boys bundled up their equipment and within seconds, the Konker found himself looking out from a very great height, bumping and juggling along the stoney path which led out of the woods.

THE TWO BOYS were too excited to ask any more questions. They rushed on with hardly a glance back. But there was a lot they didn't know about Konkers; a lot more than they had bargained for, and their 'luck'

was about to change in the most surprising ways.

CHAPTER 2

DOLAN

Before they had gone very far, they were stopped in their tracks. Ted Dolan, the school bully, leapt out from behind a tree and barred their way forward.

"Right then!" he said. "Let's see what you've found!"

"Get out of our way Dolan," panted Billy. "It's none of your business!"

"You'd better show me what you have there, or else!" demanded Dolan.

"There's nothing", said Tommy "Look!" He opened his satchel slowly and pushed the Konker out of sight.

"You see?" He said. "Just our fishing things."

Dolan grabbed the strap and pulled it from Tommy's shoulder.

"You fished something out of that river and I want to see what it is," he said, turning the bag upside down and shaking out its contents.

Tommy and Billy held their breath, expecting to see the Konker tumble out any minute, but only a ball of string and a half-eaten sandwich fell to the ground. "You see," said Tommy, "I told you there was nothing!"

DOLAN THREW the bag to the ground and caught hold of Tommy's jacket.

"Come on. don't try to kid me, you're hiding something!" he shouted.

"Leave him alone!" called Billy and tried to pull him off.

"LEAVE HIM ALONE!" boomed another great voice.

Ted Dolan froze on the spot. "Who was that?" he whimpered.

"I am the ghost of O'Hara McGhee!" it bellowed.

"He who fights in this place will my enemy be; FOREVER!

Flee! Flee BEFORE I CATCH THEE!"

The air was shaking with the sound and Dolan was shaking in his shoes. He let go of Tommy's jacket and stag-

gered back. “Run for it! He shouted. “This place is haunted!”

IN A SECOND, he was off like a hound after a hare without waiting for anyone. Tommy and Billy stood stock still. Too surprised and puzzled to move.

“Hi!” said a much smaller voice from somewhere on the ground. They looked down and there, popping out of the satchel, was the missing Konker.

”I HELD ON VERY TIGHT,” he explained. “Did I scare him? Has he gone?”

“I thought you had something to do with it!” said Billy. “but how? How did you do it?”

The Konker smiled a very little smile. "Do you want to hear more?" he said.

They both nodded and so the Konker showed them what he could really do.

He closed his eyes and hummed a tune. All at once there was music everywhere; not just humming, but the most magnificent orchestra was playing his tune. Just when they were about to applaud, it changed again. First it was a fire engine, then a lion roaring, then finally a siren. There seemed to be no sound he couldn't create.

"IT'S FANTASTIC!" cheered Billy. "But I still don't know how you do it!

"I just do it," said the Konker. "Every Konker has his own special gift, and this is mine. I make sounds, and my name is Spencer, by the way!

"You've saved our skins, Spencer. Can we do something for you?" said Tommy. "Well, you can save me a long walk and take me home," said the Konker. "All right," said the boys. "Which way?"

SPENCER KONK POINTED to the heart of the woods. "That's the way," he said.

CHAPTER 3

SMALL BEGINNING

Neither Tommy nor Billy could have guessed what was about to happen to them as Spencer Konk pointed to the spot where his home lay. Waiting there, at the entrance of Konker World, were three of Spencer's friends.

The first was a large plump Konker called Martha. She was at least twice the size of the two other Konkers who were with her, one of whom was called Maji Konk, and the other was Master Konk. They were all talking quietly to each other when the boys suddenly walked into the clearing.

Martha dropped the flowers she had picked and Master Konk straightened to attention. Only Maji seemed unruffled. At first it was only the boys they saw, then they noticed Spencer Konk in Tommy's top pocket.

"Look out!" yelled Master Konk. "They've got Spencer and they're coming this way. Do something Maji!"

Maji Konk smiled as Master Konk dived, head first, behind a rock.

"Don't panic!" called Spencer. "I just want them to see the Konker World. Can they, Master Konk?"

Master Konk stayed very still for a second, then slowly

stood up and peered out from behind the large stone. He didn't look too happy.

"SPENCER!" he bellowed. "Never do that again. You might have given poor Martha a terrible shock!"

He stepped out from behind the rock and carefully adjusted his waistcoat. "Now, who are these new friends of yours?" He nodded kindly to Tommy and Billy.

"They saved my life," said Spencer excitedly. "I met them by accident and then they hid me from that boy Dolan, who is always causing us trouble!"

"That Bully? Is he back in the woods again? Say no more, we are wasting time. Of course, they are welcome here. Let's get inside quickly before he catches all of us!"

Maji Konk stepped forward and looked up at the two boys

"I think we have a problem here. We will have to do something about these two first."

"What do you mean? Said Tommy, a little worried.

"Well," said Maji, "you are far too big to fit into our world."

Both the boys felt a little disappointed. They had been looking forward to seeing the home of these strange creatures.

But Maji continued. "Now I have got to change you to our size, so stand still!

Spencer Konk leapt out of Tommy's pocket and onto the ground.

"What's happening?" shouted Billy as Maji snapped his fingers and both he and Tommy began to shrink. Soon they were knee high to a grasshopper and looking at the world from an entirely different angle. Daisies towered above them like huge umbrellas, and trees looked like gigantic pillars reaching into the sky.

"Quickly!" called Master Konk, interrupting their

"whoops" and yells of amazement. "There is no time for that now. We must get you inside before he comes looking for you! They hurried the two friends to a large opening at the base of a tree, where they found a little car waiting for them. Maji Konk sat at the wheel and Martha squeezed in the back with Tommy and Billy.

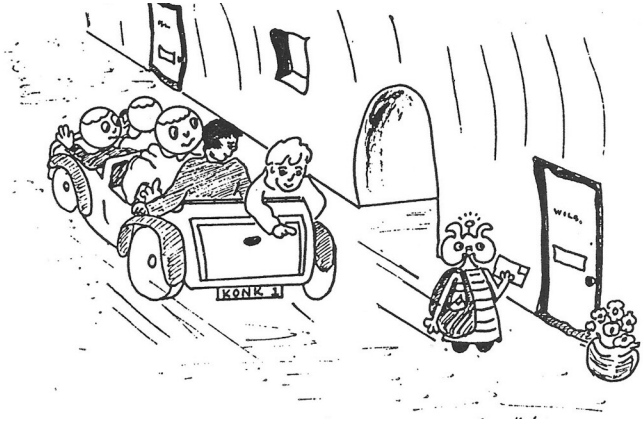
"You go on," said Master Konk, as he told Spencer to get into the other seat. "I have had quite enough excitement for one day. All I want is a nice quiet walk. Go and enjoy yourselves. Off you go!"

The boys joined in as everyone waved back at Master Konk. On they went and drove into a whole new world**, the World of Konker!**

CHAPTER 4

EXPLORING KONKER

The car travelled deeper into Konker World. Down and down it went through tunnels which were surprisingly bright and cheerful. There were doors and windows in the walls and occasionally they would see Konkers standing in little groups or walking briskly along passages. Now and then, a little mini robot whizzed past them. "What are those?" asked Tommy in surprise. Maji Konk explained that they were "Postie-bots" which delivered the post.



Another robot was directing the traffic and yet another was handing out drinks and cakes to a group of young Konkers on the way to a picnic.

They travelled on past market places in huge wide caverns and through parks and forests, all tended by Konkers and their robot helpers. They visited a giant cinema, which took up the entire space inside one particular cavern. On one wall was a wide screen and on the opposite was a platform on which they were told a "cine-bot" stood and projected the film.

"I must leave you now," said Martha Konk. "It's time I did some work."

"Have a nice time," she called as she left them.

"Now where shall we go?" asked Spencer.

"Anywhere," laughed Billy. "As long as it's in Konker. I think this place is fantastic. It's really cool!"

"Yeah!" echoed Tommy. "Let's see all of it. I've never seen anything like this, EVER!"

"Hold on then," said Maji and started the engine.

"Wait for me!" called a Konker, who came running up to them.

"Hello Shuffle," said Spencer. "Do you want a lift?"

"Yes," said Shuffle. "I'm going to Uncle Burrows."

"Can we go that way, Maji?" asked Spencer.

Maji turned and waved a warning finger at Shuffle. "As long as there are no tricks or pranks!" he said sternly.

"I'll be good. I promise! said Shuffle and immediately jumped into the car. "Hi!" he said cheerfully as he sat down opposite the two boys.

They looked closely at the smiling Konker, who was sitting opposite them. Why did Maji Konk give him such a stern warning? He looked innocent enough.

"Hello! said Tommy, as politely as he could..

The Konker's smile became even broader and there was a mischievous glint in his eyes as he said, "I was a human once, just for a laugh!"

Tommy gasped in amazement. "What!" he stammered, "are you really a human?"

"Of course not!" laughed Shuffle and to Tommy's surprise, Maji and Spencer laughed too.

"What's so funny?" said Tommy, a little peeved. "He did say he was a human, didn't he?"

"Yes, he did! said Spencer. "But he didn't mean it the way you think. It would be easier to show you than to explain." He turned to Maji. "Can he show them what his special gift is? Just this once, please. He will be careful, won't you, Shuff?"

Shuffle nodded eagerly and waited for Maji Konk to say yes.

"Oh, all right then," said Maji quietly. "But don't make me crash!"

"Whatever next?" wondered Tommy.

He was about to find out!

CHAPTER 5

SHUFFLE'S SURPRISE

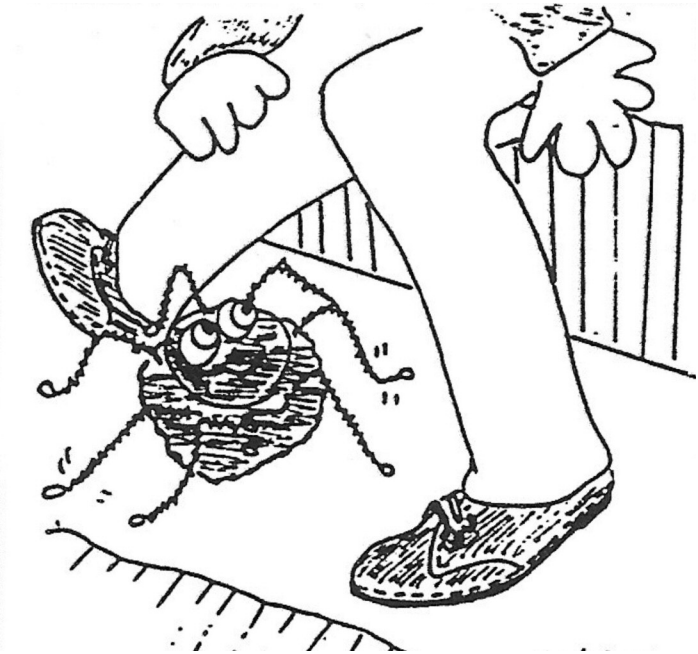
"Come on, then!" said Billy impatiently as Shuffle Konk sat looking at him. "What is this special gift of yours? Is it acrobatics, high jumping or what?"

"None of those. It's this," said Shuffle and disappeared.

"Hey, where did he go?" asked Billy.

"Down there," said Spencer Konk, and pointed to the floor at their feet.

Tommy and Billy looked down. Looking back up at them was a gigantic, brown spider squatting neatly between the opposite seat and Billy's left foot. Its beady little eyes were staring straight at Billy's. Then, as he watched it, it began inching its way closer and closer to his trouser leg.



"Now that's what I call a good trick," said Billy. It crept closer and closer.

"I believe you, I believe, Mr Shuffle Konk. O.K. I understand," he said, as he quickly moved his feet away.

"And if you don't mind, Mr Shuffle, er, Mr Konk, can you please change back?" He was turning a bit pale and had now moved his legs up nearly to his chin.

Spencer Konk got a bit worried and quickly leaned over to the spider. "Change back Shuff. I think he's had enough!

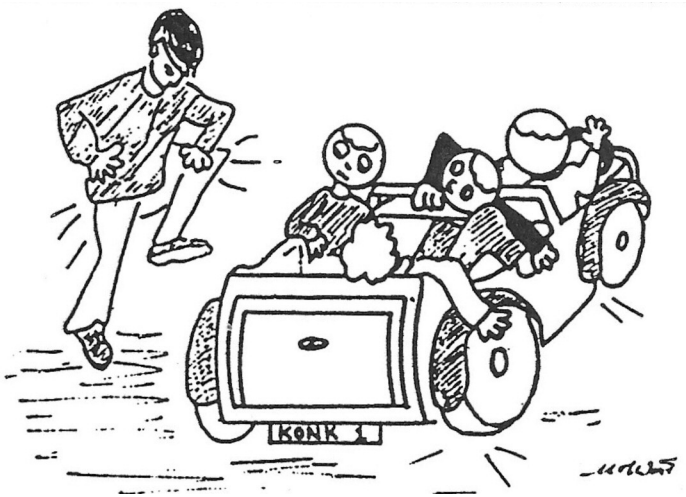
There was a silence as they all waited for the change to take place, but nothing happened. The spider was now climbing up onto the seat. First one, then another spindly leg appeared over the top.

"It's a real one!" shouted Billy. "It's not Shuffle at all. Stop the car Maji, throw it out. Quickly, it's coming for me!"

"Be careful!" called Maji from the front seat. "Sit down!"

"Let me out! Do something!" yelled Billy. "It's real, honest. Believe me, it's real!"

The car screeched to a halt inside a large cavern and everybody fell on top of one another. Billy jumped straight out and brushed madly at his clothes, but there was nothing there.



"IT'S GONE!" he muttered. Then he noticed Shuffle sitting innocently on the car seat opposite to his.

"What's all the fuss about?" he laughed. "Have you never seen a spider before?"

"SHUFFLE!" growled Maji Konk "DON"T DO THAT AGAIN!!"

"Good joke, eh?" whispered Shuffle as Billy got back into the car.

"You nearly gave me a heart attack!" he said. Then he smiled. "But it's good," he chuckled, "really good!" It had suddenly occurred to him what fun he could have at school with something like that. There and then he decided that Shuffle Konk was a Konker after his own heart. Just his type of guy!

Indeed, they were two of a kind and would soon become two of a team; a team which would carry out a very important task on behalf of all the Konkers...

CHAPTER 6

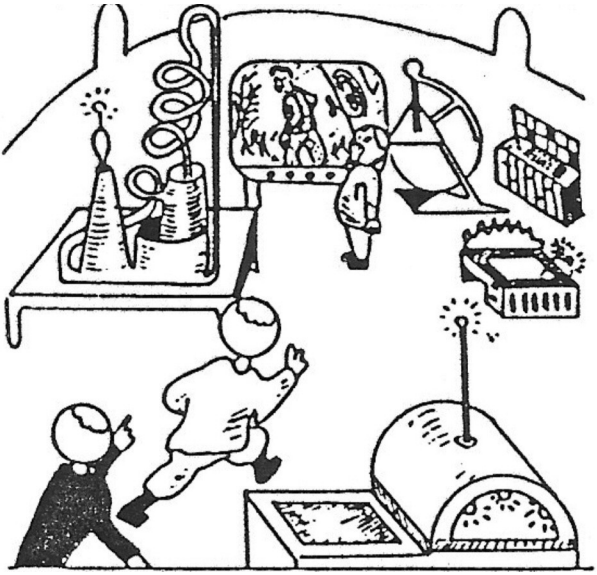
KIDNAPPED

They were just settling down again after all the fuss when a Konker called Spike came racing up to the car

"Quick Maji," he gasped, "Uncle Burrows wants you right now. Wilbert got kidnapped!"

"Jump in!" shouted Maji, and the little car took off again with Spike barely hanging on.

They screeched up to Uncle Burrows' door and leapt out. The house was an enormous cavern full of machines and flashing lights. In the centre of this arena of clicking, burring and twinkling machines stood a small chubby Konker who seemed to be much older than the others. He was scratching his chin and looking at a screen. As they came closer, they could see that it showed the outside of Konker World and could just make out the figure of someone running off through the woods.



"WE'RE HERE" called Maji.

"But alas, too late! That boy who was chasing your friends has got Wilbert Konk."

"But I thought he had gone," said Tommy in surprise.

Uncle Burrows looked kindly at Tommy and then told him the rest of what they knew about Dolan.

"You know," he said, "this is not the first time he's been here." He explained that Ted Dolan had been searching for Konkers since the first day he had caught a glimpse of one. Uncle Burrows heard him telling his friends about it and they had laughed at him. He seemed to be determined to catch one after that. "He has been prowling around here ever since," said Uncle Burrows sadly. "Who knows what he will do with him now? Or who he will tell. For all we know, everyone might come looking for us now."

Tommy was very thoughtful. It was all making sense now.

Ted Dolan must have been looking for Konker people when they had accidentally caught Spencer Konk on their fishing line. That was why he was lurking about. He was spying on them. No wonder Master Konk had rushed them underground so quickly. He knew exactly what danger they were all in. Well, now Dolan was in for a real shock. School bully or not, he needed to be taught a lesson, and Tommy knew just how to do it. But this time, it would be well planned.

"We will get him back for you," said Tommy suddenly.

Billy turned and stared at him. "We will?"

"Yes," said Tommy. "But the Konkers must help. If we work together, we can do it. How about it? Will you come with us?"

The Konkers were utterly amazed. No-one had ever offered to help them before and this was a dangerous venture. Shuffle was the only one who had ever gone into the world of humans, and that was just for a foolish dare.

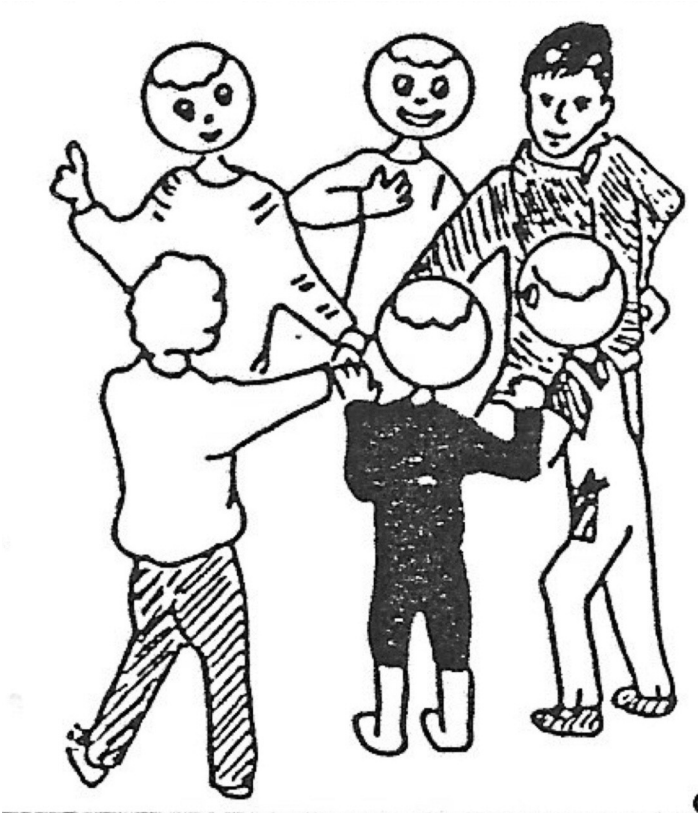
There was silence for a minute, then Maji spoke up. "I'll come with you," he said. "We must rescue Wilbert."

"Me too!" said Spencer and then Spike also agreed.

Shuffle Konk's face lit up, and he grinned widely. "Of course," he chimed in, "You are not going without ME!"

They all put their hands together and shook on it.

Now they were a team and ready for anything!



CHAPTER 7

WILBERT'S RESCUE

By now, Ted Dolan had gathered all his gang together, and they were on their way to their secret hideout in the woods.

Meanwhile, Tommy and Billy had been brought back to their proper size and were standing just outside the entrance of Konker World. Mr. Burrows had tracked the Dolan gang all the way and could see exactly where they were. Now it was up to Maji Konk to use his magic to transport the rescue team to the exact same spot in the woods. Maji did his thing and Tommy and Billy found themselves in the bushes just behind Dolan.

"Hide!" said Tommy as he spotted them and quickly took cover.

The Konkers were hidden safely in the boys" pockets and they peeped out to see what was going on. They watched the Dolan Gang go into their den and bang the door shut.

Tommy and Billy waited for a few minutes and then crept forward and peered in through a crack in the side of the den.

Inside, Dolan was glaring round at the other boys. He put the tin containing Wilbert Konk onto the table in front of him and pushed it into the middle so that everyone could see.

"Now we'll see who's imagining things!" He snarled and started to open the lid. Maji Konk could see everything. He closed his eyes and thought very hard. Then with a snap of his fingers he made the lid jam tight shut.

He looked up at Tommy.

"Now you can go in and get the tin," he called.

Tommy was not the least bit worried by this suggestion because he knew for sure that the Konkers would help him all the way. Without another thought, he pushed open the door and burst into their den.

"Grab him!" shouted Dolan and somebody lunged towards Tommy, catching him by the arm.

Meanwhile, Spike Konk had been busy in Tommy"s pocket. He had already wired up some instant defences, using the loose threads he had found in there. As soon as the other boy caught hold of Tommy's jacket, he was thrown back by a sudden flash. He reeled backwards and so did all the other boys, not sure what they were up against.

Tommy jumped forward and grabbed the metal box. The minute he did, Maji was able to finish his magic and transfer Wilbert to the safety of Tommy's other pocket.

When Wilbert was safely out of the box, Maji sent Shuffle with a message. Shuffle quickly changed into a fly and flew straight to Tommy, whispering the message right into his ear.

First, he delivered Maji's message that Wilbert was safe, and then he had a great idea of his own.

"Don't pick the box off the table!" Shuffle whispered. "Let Dolan think you are not interested anymore and he won't bother chasing you!

Tommy did as he was told and took his hands away from the tin box.

"Sorry!" he said, "Wrong box! That's not mine," he muttered and started stepping back slowly towards the door. Every eye was glued on him but nobody moved, except Dolan, who pulled at the tin lid which flew open at once.

"There!" he said triumphantly, holding out the tin in front of Tommy"s nose. "What do you think of that, then?"

Tommy peered inside and picked out a perfectly ordinary nut; a round, shiny conker. He lifted it up and inspected it.

"Very nice indeed! he said, trying not to laugh. "Sorry, I haven't time to play right now. I'm in an awful rush!"

He threw the conker back and made a quick dash for the door. Behind him, he could hear Dolan trying to stop his gang from laughing.

"Where are its legs then?" they were saying and "You haven't got a talking peanut as well, have you?"

Poor Dolan, for once he was stumped.

Billy and Tommy took the Konkers back to the safety of the woods and warned Wilbert not to be so careless again. They stayed and talked about the adventure a little, but they all knew it was time to say goodbye and go back to their own separate worlds.

Spike, the electronic genius of Konker World, popped his head out of Tommy"s pocket.

"This has been great fun," he said, in rather a serious, deep voice, "so I brought something for you. You must keep it very safe." He handed him a tiny black box with a red button on top. "This will help you to contact us again!" he said.

"What do we do with it?" asked Tommy.

"Oh just press the button when you want to visit or talk with us," said Maji. "We will do the rest."

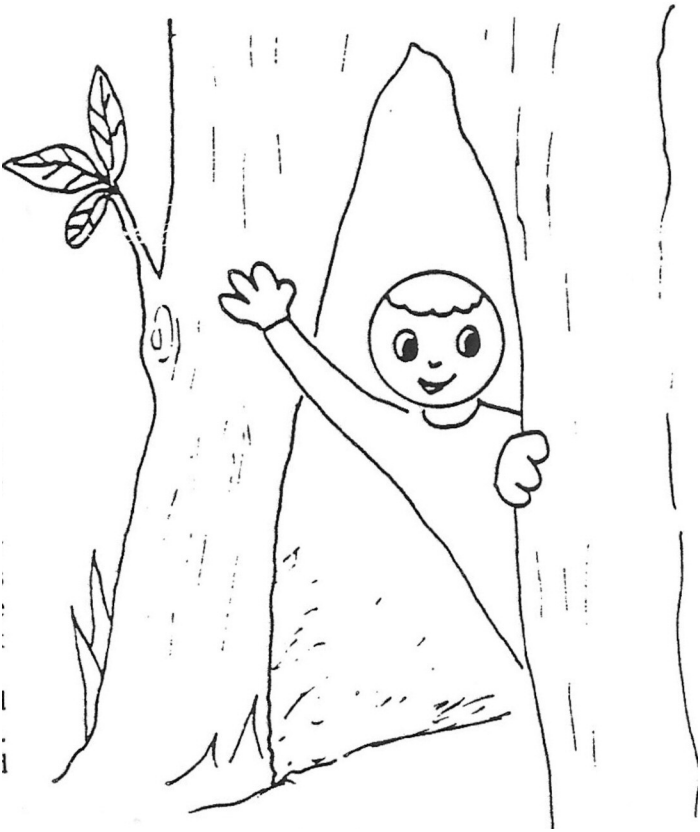
Tommy and Billy looked at the little box sitting on Tommy"s palm.

"Thanks!" both boys said together. Now, it wasn't so hard to wave goodbye.

"I know we will see you again," said Maji with a smile and everyone agreed.

Then, with a last wave, all the Konks disappeared.

The two boys stood for a minute. "See you soon," they called into the quiet woods and, laughing and smiling, they went off home.



Goodbye Maji. We will see you later.